

mammogram and lab work would go towards my deductible, thus lowering my actual responsibility.

I politely declined and explained my reasoning, and they didn't have a problem with it at all. Sure enough, when the charges eventually came through my insurance company, I actually owed less to the hospital than they initially told me.

Even though the hospital may try to boss you around, you have more negotiating power than you think. The next time they ask you to pay everything upfront, don't give in, and let it run through your insurance first!